

TOPIC 2: PHRASES

TYPES OF PHRASES

A phrase is a group of words that do not contain a finite verb. A phrase cannot stand on its own to make meaning. It only form part of a sentence.

Types of phrases

Noun phrase: This is the phrase that does the work of a noun or pronoun in a sentence.

Example:

John the driver is dead.

The big ugly girl is quarrelsome.

Adjectival phrase: This is the phrase that describes a noun or a pronoun in a sentence. Examples:

The coat made of cotton is very lovely.

The girl with dirty hands ate the food.

Adverbial phrase: this is the phrase that modifies a verb in a sentence. It answers the question “why, where, when, how? etc. Examples:

The head boy lives near the church.

The old man walked slowly across the road.

Prepositional phrase: This is a phrase that begins with a preposition. Examples

Sani was beaten with a cane.

The woman drowned in the river.

Identification of phrases

If the verbs in the expression given is preceded by 'to' that verb is non-finite, therefore the expression is a phrase. Example

He is always ready to fight anybody.

To pass examination involves hard work.

If the verb in the expression functions as an adjective, it is a non-finite verb and therefore the expression becomes a phrase. Example

I have boiled yam in my pot.

He has replaced the broken bottle.

If the verb in the expression is in the '-ing' form, the verb is non-finite and the expression becomes a phrase. Example

I saw the boy going to the library.

Eating supper late is what I don't like.

If the expression underlined in the sentence cannot make meaning when standing alone. Example

She is sleeping in the room.

They are standing outside the gate.